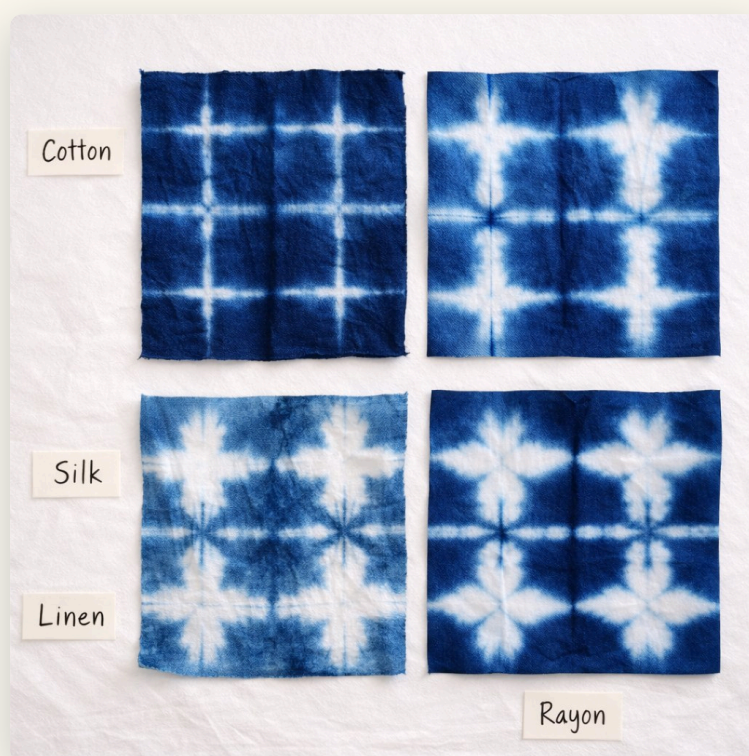


The Fabric Guide: Which Fabrics Produce The Best Results

The same fold looks completely different on cotton, silk, linen, and rayon. This guide shows you exactly what to expect from each.



One fold, one indigo bath, four fabrics — and four completely different results.

In shibori, the cloth is **half the result**. Bind the same fold and dip it in the same indigo, and cotton comes out crisp and graphic while rayon bleeds into a soft blur — before you change a thing about your hands. Learn what each fibre does, and you choose your result.

WHAT'S INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- ◆ Cotton, silk, linen, and rayon — the same technique compared side by side
- ◆ Where to source the best fabrics for under \$5 a yard, online and locally
- ◆ How to prep each fabric so the dye bonds evenly and the pattern comes through crisp
- ◆ The best fabric for each technique, for the strongest, most vivid result

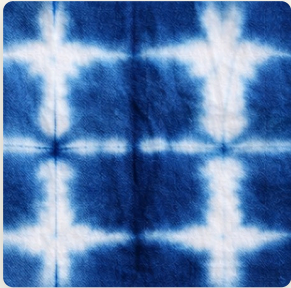
The Four Fabrics, Side by Side

The very same shibori fold, bound and dipped in the same indigo on each fabric in turn. Look at the edges — that is the fibre talking.



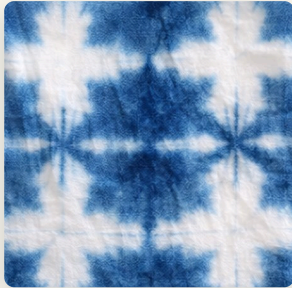
Cotton

DEEP, EVEN BLUE



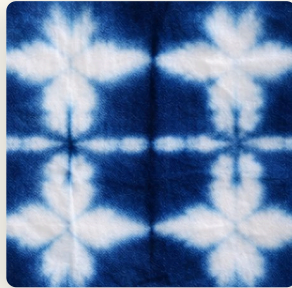
Silk

LUSTROUS GLOW



Linen

RICH, TEXTURED BLUE



Rayon

SATURATED, SOFT

Cotton — *deep, even blue*

The shibori workhorse. This cellulose fibre drinks indigo readily and holds a crisp, high-contrast edge wherever the resist binds it. Predictable, forgiving, and the cheapest cloth you can dye.

DYE UPTAKE

High

EDGE

Crisp

BEST FOR

Sharp
graphic
patterns

Silk — *lustrous glow*

A protein fibre with a natural sheen. It takes the dye with a soft, luminous glow — edges stay defined, but gentler than cotton. The luxurious result, and the most rewarding to wear.

DYE UPTAKE

Med-high

EDGE

Soft-
defined

BEST FOR

Luminous,
elegant
pieces

Linen — *rich, textured blue*

A strong, characterful cellulose fibre. It drinks indigo deeply, and its slubby weave hands the pattern a rugged, organic edge that cotton can never quite match.

DYE UPTAKE

High

EDGE

Rugged

BEST FOR

Bold,
organic
texture

Rayon — *saturated, soft*

A semi-synthetic regenerated fibre, and the thirstiest of the four. Dye spreads and bleeds, so edges turn soft and watercolour-like — fluid and vivid, but never crisp.

DYE UPTAKE

Very high

EDGE

Soft bleed

BEST FOR

Drapey,
painterly
work

Where To Source — Under \$5 A Yard

Good shibori cloth is cheap cloth. These three sources cover every fabric in this guide and leave money in your pocket.

1 Cotton — Muslin & Old Sheets — *the cheapest cloth of all*

Unbleached cotton muslin is the lowest-cost dyeable fabric there is, and a thrifted 100% cotton bedsheet costs next to nothing. Both take indigo beautifully.

LOOK FOR Unbleached cotton muslin off the bolt, or 100% cotton sheets from a thrift store.

BUY IT [amazon.com](#) > “cotton muslin fabric” — or any thrift store.

PRICE about \$2–4 a yard

2 Rayon & Linen-Blend — *rich colour, low cost*

Rayon challis and linen blends dye richly and stay cheap straight off the bolt — and the remnant bin is cheaper still.

LOOK FOR Rayon challis, or a linen / cotton blend in a plain weave.

BUY IT [amazon.com](#) > “rayon challis fabric” — or fabric-store remnant bins.

PRICE about \$3–5 a yard

3 Silk — Buy It Small — *the splurge of the four*

Silk costs the most, so keep your pieces small. Habotai (china silk) is the most affordable weave, and blank silk scarves arrive ready to dye.

LOOK FOR Habotai silk by the half-yard, or ready-to-dye blank silk scarves.

BUY IT [amazon.com](#) > “habotai silk fabric” — or Dharma Trading Co.

PRICE about \$4–8 a small piece

Check the label first. Indigo bonds only to natural fibres — cotton, linen, rayon, and silk all qualify. Polyester, acrylic, and nylon will not take indigo at all; if a fabric is more than about a third synthetic, leave it on the shelf.

How To Prep Each Fabric

Skip preparation and the dye lands patchy and pale. A little work before the indigo bath is what makes the pattern bond even and crisp.

FIRST, FOR EVERY FABRIC — SCOUR IT

Every new fabric carries invisible **sizing, oils, and mill finishes** that fight the dye. A thorough wash before you fold a single pleat is what lets indigo bond evenly — skip it and the colour comes out blotchy. And always work **damp**: bind and dip while the cloth is still wet.

Cotton

Scour it first — a hot wash with a spoon of soda ash or plain detergent strips the mill finish that blocks dye. Then bind and dip it damp, never dry, so the indigo penetrates evenly.

Silk

Scour gently: mild detergent in warm — never hot — water, since harsh soda ash dulls silk's sheen. Pre-wet it fully before binding so the dye takes without blotching.

Linen

Linen carries heavy sizing — scour it hot, and wash it twice if the water still runs cloudy. Soak it right through before dyeing; its dense weave is slow to wet.

Rayon

Rayon is weak while wet, so handle it gently. Scour in warm water with mild detergent, and never wring it — squeeze the water out and support the cloth as you lift.

Then bind it damp. Fold, clamp, or stitch your resist while the fabric is still wet from its pre-soak — damp cloth creases sharper and holds the resist far tighter than dry cloth ever will.

PART FOUR

The Best Fabric For Each Technique

Match the fabric to the technique and the result gets stronger on its own — no extra skill required.

Itajime — folded & clamped shapes

COTTON

Crisp clamped edges and the highest contrast of the four — geometry stays razor-sharp.

Nui — stitched & gathered lines

LINEN

Strong fibres hold a tight gather without tearing; the line comes through rugged and defined.

Kanoko — bound dots

SILK

Tiny bound points glow luminous against the indigo — the classic kimono technique.

Arashi — pole-wrapped diagonals

COTTON

Firm cotton pleats lock in fine, even diagonal lines that hold their crispness.

Ombré & soft painterly bleeds

RAYON

Let the thirstiest fibre blur every edge into a soft watercolour gradient.

THE ONE RULE TO REMEMBER

When in doubt, reach for **cotton**. It is the cheapest, the most predictable, and it takes indigo crisp and even — the safe choice while your hands are still learning the folds. Save **silk** for the pieces you mean to wear, and **rayon** for the days you want the dye to bleed and surprise you.

Choose the cloth first, and half the pattern is already decided.